

2c. Content of Developments in Buddhist thought (H573/06)

In this component, learners have the opportunity to undertake a systematic study of key concepts within the development of Buddhist thought. Learners will explore religious beliefs, values and teachings, their interconnections, how they have developed historically and how they are presently discussed.

This component examines the foundations of Buddhism, investigating both the significance and context of the Buddha as a source of wisdom and authority, as well as the importance of the *Three Refuges* in expressing Buddhist identity and acting as the underlying principles of Buddhist teachings.

The key teachings of Buddhism and their interconnections form the basis of the topics *Samsara*, *The Three Marks* and the *Four Noble Truths*. Exploration of these will provide students with insight into Buddhist beliefs about ultimate reality, the self, the meaning of life and death. These teachings also form the foundations of Buddhist practice and key moral principles.

The practice of meditation is studied in detail, with an emphasis on the personal nature of meditative practice and the diversity of methods used by Buddhists.

The development of Mahayana Buddhism was pivotal in the historical development of Buddhism, and the distinctive ideas and philosophy of these schools, including the Madhyamaka, will stretch and challenge learners, introducing them to the truly diverse range of ideas and traditions within Buddhism.

Learners will further develop their understanding of the variety within Buddhist tradition by examining Buddhist practices and ideas in two very different cultural contexts: the Far East and the West. This will enable them to investigate different interpretations of Buddhist teachings and examine the relationship between religion and society.

This investigation continues in the topic considering *Engaged Buddhism and Activism*, which enables students to focus on how this interesting and modern approach to Buddhism responds to issues and ideas highly relevant to learners and the world around them.

The final topic explores the changing roles of men and women across history, societies and Buddhist traditions. These issues will be familiar and relevant to learners, and enable discussion of identity, equality, discrimination, religious freedom and the relationship between religion and society.

Technical Terms

While the majority of non-English terms (which are not names of texts, philosophical schools, or particular religious approaches) within the specification and assessment materials will be accompanied by a translation, there are some that are considered to be key technical terms that learners are expected to recognise and understand without a provided translation.

For this component, the following are considered technical terms and will not necessarily be accompanied by a translation:

- *Bodhisattva*
- *Buddha*

- *Dhamma/Dharma*
- *Jhana*
- *Kamma/Karma*
- *Nibbana/Nirvana*
- *Samatha*
- *Samsara*
- *Sangha/Samgha*
- *Skandhas*
- *Vipassana*.

The spelling of words which have been transliterated from non-Roman alphabets will be used consistently through the assessment materials. Learners will not be penalised for the use of other common spellings.

1. Foundations

The origins and development of Buddhism, and the sources of wisdom on which it is based

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
The Buddha*	- Siddhartha's life - the Buddha's intellectual context	- Key details of Siddhartha's life story and their significance to Buddhists and Buddhism: - birth and hedonistic upbringing - the four passing sights - renunciation - asceticism - enlightenment - teaching career - the influence of Brahmanism and Sramana movements, including Jainism: - the importance of Brahmanism in the Buddha's contemporary culture; his criticisms of the Brahmins and their ideas; his use and adaptation of Brahmin ideas - the Buddha's experience of Sramana movements and teachers; his use and adaptation of their ideas
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to the Buddha and his role as a source of wisdom and authority, including: - how the example of Siddhartha might be used in teaching and practice, including illustration of the Middle Way - the limitations of the Buddha as an example to Buddhists; the importance of self-reliance and the idea of <i>ehipassiko/ehipaśyika</i> ('come and try'), not blind faith and devotion - the ways in which the cultural context affects the development of ideas		
Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Dhammapada 153–4 - Erricker, C. (2001 2nd edition) <i>Teach Yourself Buddhism</i>, Teach Yourself Chapter 2 - Della Santina, P. (1970) <i>The Fundamentals of Buddhism</i>, Buddha Dharma Education Association Ltd, Chapter 1 (available online) - Cush, D. (1994), <i>Buddhism</i>, Hodder Education, Chapter 2		

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Taking Refuge*	- the Three Refuges/Jewels: <i>Buddha</i> <i>Dhamma/Dharma</i> <i>Sangha/Samgha</i>	- the significance of the Refuges for Buddhists and how Buddhists ‘take refuge’ - the different understandings of <i>Buddha</i>, including both as the historical person of Siddhartha and as an ideal - the meanings of the term <i>dhamma/dharma</i>, including as unmediated Truth or ultimate reality, and as the teachings of the Buddha - the various meanings and significance of <i>sangha/samgha</i>, including as one’s spiritual community or close associates, the monastic Sangha and its relationship with the laity, and also all Buddhists past, present and future
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to the Refuges, including: - their role in expressing Buddhist identity - different interpretations of what each means and how one takes refuge in them in practice - why these ideals are seen as the heart of Buddhism	
	Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - The Pali formula for Taking Refuge (The Khuddakapatha (Khp) 1) - Saddhatissa, H. (1997) <i>Buddhist Ethics</i>, Wisdom Publications, Chapter 3 - Anguttara Nikaya (AN) 11.12	

2. Insight

Beliefs, teachings and ideas about human life, the world and ultimate reality

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Samsara*	<i>samsara</i> and the six realms of existence - how these relate to: <i>punabbhava/punarbhava</i> (rebirth) - the three fires/poisons <i>kamma/karma</i> <i>paticcasamuppada/pratityasamutpada</i> (dependent origination)	- details of each of the six realms, including the nature of the realms and the beings within them, related karmic causes and significance of the human realm for liberation - the nature of each of these teachings and their relationship to the wheel of <i>samsara</i> and the beings within it
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues related to the idea of <i>Samsara</i>, including: - whether <i>samsara</i> should be understood metaphorically, psychologically or literally - how important <i>samsara</i> and the associated ideas are in Buddhist everyday practice - which actions cause <i>kamma/karma</i> and which do not; karmic seeds and fruits		
Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Harvey, P. (2000) <i>An Introduction to Buddhist Ethics; Foundations, Values and Issues</i>, Cambridge University Press, Chapter 1 - The Tibetan Wheel of Life <i>The Questions of King Milinda</i> Book II Chapter 2		

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
The Three Marks of Existence*	• <i>anicca/anitya</i> (impermanence) • <i>dukkha/duhkha</i> (suffering) • <i>anatta/anatman</i> (no self)	• the nature of <i>anicca/anitya</i>, including: ◦ both the gross and subtle/momentary level ◦ how it links to both <i>dukkha</i> and <i>anatta/anatman</i> • the nature of <i>dukkha/duhkha</i>, including: ◦ different translations and understandings of the term ◦ the three 'categories' of <i>dukkha</i>: 'ordinary' suffering, suffering arising from change and the suffering of conditioned experience ◦ the types of unavoidable suffering • the nature of <i>anatta/anatman</i>, including: ◦ the rejection of both eternalism and annihilationism ◦ the explanation offered by chariot analogy in <i>The Questions of King Milinda</i> (Book II, Chapter 1.1) ◦ the understanding of the five <i>khandhas/skandhas</i>
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues relating to the three marks, including: • whether or not all of conditioned experience truly is subject to these marks • whether Buddhism is inherently pessimistic, optimistic or realistic about the human condition • whether or not any of the marks are more or less important than the others	
	Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful • Cush, D. (1994) <i>Buddhism</i>, Hodder Education, Chapter 2, pages 35–38 • Gethin, R. (1998) <i>The Foundations of Buddhism</i>, Oxford University Press, Chapter 6 • Harvey, P. (2000) <i>An Introduction to Buddhist Ethics; Foundations, Values and Issues</i>, Cambridge University Press, Chapter 1 pages 33–36	

3. Living

The diversity of ethics and practice, including those that shape and express religious identity, the role of the community of believers and key moral principles

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Four Noble Truths*	- the Four Noble Truths: <i>dukkha/duhkha</i> (suffering) <i>tanha/trishna</i> (craving) <i>nibbana/nirvana</i> <i>magga/marga</i> (path)	- the Four Noble Truths as the foundation of Buddhist teaching, including: - the doctor analogy: the illness, the cause of the illness, the truth that there is an end to the illness, and the prescription - the outline given in the <i>Deer Park Sermon</i> (as recorded in <i>Samyutta Nikaya</i> 56.11) - the path of disciples and <i>arhats/arahants</i> who follow the teachings <i>dukkha/duhkha</i> as it relates to the other three Truths and its role as the ‘sickness’ to be cured - the different types of craving (craving for material pleasures, craving for existence, craving for non-existence) and how they lead to suffering <i>tanha</i> as one of the 12 <i>nidanas</i> (causes) <i>nirvana</i> as the goal of Buddhism, including: <i>nirodha</i> as the ‘cutting off’ of craving through detachment <i>nibbana/nirvana</i>-with-remainder and <i>parinibbana/parinirvana</i> <i>nibbana/nirvana</i> as un-conditioned existence which cannot be explained - the issues raised by the 79th and 80th dilemmas of <i>The Questions of King Milinda</i> - the (Noble) Eightfold Path and its goal, including: - the eight stages and three sections (wisdom, ethics, meditation) - the stages as inter-reliant, not linear - the ninth and tenth ‘acquired’ stages of wisdom
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues relating to the Four Noble Truths, including: - whether or not the goal of Buddhism can be understood - whether the Buddhist idea of detachment is positive or negative - whether any of the Truths, or stages of the eightfold path, are more or less important than the others		

	Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> • Gethin, R. (1998) <i>The Foundations of Buddhism</i>, Oxford University Press, Chapter 3 • Harvey, P. (2012 2nd edition) <i>An Introduction to Buddhism: Teachings, History and Practices (Introduction to Religion)</i> Chapter 3 • Keown, D. (2000) <i>Buddhism: A Very Short Introduction</i>, Oxford University Press, Chapter 4	
Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Meditation*	• methods of meditation	• the nature of <i>samatha</i> and <i>vipassana/vipaśyanā</i> meditation ◦ their goals ◦ how they complement each other ◦ examples of practice • the role of mindfulness in Buddhist practice • the importance of personalised practice
	• the aims and results of meditation	• meditation as a stage of the Eightfold Path • the benefits and effects of meditation, including its use in secular, therapeutic contexts • experiences of <i>jhanas/dhyanas</i>
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues relating to meditation, including: • whether or not meditation has to be a religious practice • whether or not meditation is the most important element of Buddhist practice • whether or not meditation encourages an unhealthy 'inward looking' approach to life	
	Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> • Gethin, R. (1998) <i>The Foundations of Buddhism</i>, Oxford University Press, Chapter 7 • <i>Vipassana Meditation: As taught by S.N. Goenka in the tradition of Sayagyi U Ba Khin</i> (https://www.dhamma.org/en/index) • Bhikkhu Bodhi, (2005) <i>Two Styles of Insight Meditation</i>, Access to Insight (Legacy Edition), [http://www.accesstoinight.org/lib/authors/bodhi/bps-essay_45.html] • Thanissaro Bhikkhu (1997) <i>The Path of Concentration & Mindfulness</i>, Access to Insight (Legacy Edition), [http://www.accesstoinight.org/lib/authors/thanissaro/concmind.html]	

4. Development

Significant social and historical developments in Buddhist thought, such as those influenced by ethics, philosophy or studies of religion

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
The Development of Mahayana Buddhism	- the development of Mahayana Buddhism - the <i>bodhisattva</i> ideal and its significance - the <i>trikaya</i> (three bodies of the Buddha)	- a general introduction, including: - possible reasons for its emergence - the context of its emergence - the idea of <i>upaya</i> (skilful means) and how this is applied to the original teachings of Siddhartha - including: - details of the <i>bodhisattva</i> vow and way - the six <i>paramitas</i> (perfections) and their significance - comparison with the Theravada <i>arhat</i> - key <i>bodhisattvas</i> and what they represent, including: - Avalokiteśvara - Manjusri - Maitreya - the above to be studied with reference to the following parables from the <i>Lotus Sutra</i>: - the burning house (chapter 3) - the magic city (chapter 7) - the hidden gem (chapter 8) - understanding of the nature and significance of: - the truth body - the heavenly body - the earthly body
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues relating to key Mahayana ideas, including: - the differences and similarities between the <i>bodhisattva</i> and the <i>arhat/arahant</i> and their paths - how the nature of the <i>bodhisattva</i> can be explained - the implications, in terms of responses to other religious truth claims and diversity within Buddhism, of the idea of <i>upaya</i> (skilful means) - the development in the understanding of 'Buddha' illustrated by the <i>trikaya</i> doctrine		
Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Lotus Sutra, Chapter 2 - Ven. Bhikkhu Bodhi, (2013) <i>Arahants, Bodhisattvas, and Buddhas</i>, Access to Insight (Legacy Edition) [online] - Gethin, R. (1998) <i>The Foundations of Buddhism</i>, Oxford University Press, Chapter 9		

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Madhyamaka and Prajnaparamita	• Madhyamaka philosophy and <i>prajnaparamita</i> (perfection of wisdom) • the following with reference to the ideas of Nagarjuna: ◦ <i>sunyata/sunnata</i> (emptiness) ◦ two truths ◦ <i>samsara</i> and <i>nirvana/nibbana</i>	• the role of Nagarjuna in the development of these ideas • the importance of the <i>Prajnaparamita Sutras</i>, including the content and interpretation of the <i>Heart Sutra</i> • different interpretations of <i>sunyata/sunnata</i> and what it means for all things to be empty of <i>svabhava/sabhava</i> (own being) • the distinction between relative and ultimate truths and why recognition of this distinction is important for liberation • the claim that <i>samsara</i> and <i>nirvana/nibbana</i> should not be understood as different things
	Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues relating to Madhyamaka philosophy and the <i>Prajnaparamita</i> sutras and their significance in Mahayana Buddhism, including: • the practical implications of these concepts for Buddhist life • how far these teachings are separate from, and discontinuous with, the teachings of the historical Buddha • if words and teachings are merely conventions, whether or not they still have value	
	Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Nagarjuna listed above can be found in:</i> • <i>Fundamental Verses on the Middle Way</i> Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> • Harvey, P. (2012 2nd edition) <i>An Introduction to Buddhism: Teachings, History and Practices (Introduction to Religion)</i>, Cambridge University Press Chapter 5 • Della Santina, P. (2002) <i>Causality and Emptiness: The Wisdom of Nagarjuna</i>, Buddha Dharma Education Association Ltd (available online)	

5. Society

The relationship between religion and society, including issues such as how religions adapt when encountering different cultures; religious tolerance, respect and recognition and views of other religions and non-religious worldviews; religion, equality and discrimination; the political and social influence of religious institutions

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Buddhism in the Far East	- Zen Buddhism - Pure Land Buddhism	- the distinctive features of Zen Buddhism, including: <i>zazen</i> meditation, its importance and the attainment of <i>satori</i> (awakening) - Zen attitudes to scripture and transmission of wisdom - key features of and differences between the Rinzaï and Soto schools - the distinctive features of Pure Land Buddhism, including: - the person and importance of Amitabha - rebirth in a Pure Land - the practice of chanting, its importance and purpose - key features of and differences between Jōdo-shū and Jōdo Shinshū
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues relating to Zen and Pure Land ideas, including: - whether Pure Land Buddhism is an ‘easy’ path - how and if Siddhartha’s original teachings can be seen in these two schools - the implications of Zen’s rejection of theory, ritual and the use of language to express truth		
Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - The Flower Sermon (various traditions and versions exist) - Cush, D. (1994) <i>Buddhism</i>, Hodder Education, Chapter 4, pages 123–150 - Suzuki, D. T. (Author) and Dobbins, J. C. (Editor) (2015) <i>Selected Works of D.T. Suzuki, Volume II: Pure Land</i>, University of California Press, Chapters 1, 2 and 4		

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Buddhism in the West	- the spread of Buddhism to the West - Buddhism in popular culture - Western 'inculturation'	- the main reasons for the spread of Buddhism, such as migration and the popularity of Buddhist ideas in modern western societies - exploration of how Buddhism is portrayed in the West, including: - media stereotypes and depiction of Buddhist role models, including portrayals of figures such as the Dalai Lama - the ways in which Buddhism has changed and adapted on encountering Western science, ideas and culture, including: - the ideas of Secular Buddhism, with reference to Stephen Batchelor - the interplay of Christianity and Buddhism, the idea of 'dual-belonging', with reference to Paul Knitter
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues relating to Buddhism in the West, including: - a comparison of the approaches and ideas of Stephen Batchelor and Paul Knitter, and the ways in which they have adopted and 'Westernised' Buddhist ideas - how the depiction of Buddhism in the Western media, including the fame of figures such as the Dalai Lama, shape (and possibly distort) Western understandings of Buddhism - comparison of how figures such as the Dalai Lama are viewed by Buddhists and non-Buddhists, and their significance to each group		
Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Batchelor and Knitter listed above can be found in:</i> - Batchelor, S. <i>Buddhism Without Beliefs</i> - Knitter, P. <i>Without Buddha I could not be a Christian</i> Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Thich Nhat Hanh, (1996) <i>Living Buddha, Living Christ</i>, Rider - Garfield, J. L. (2010) <i>Buddhism in the West</i>, Tibetan Buddhism in the West, online [http://info-buddhism.com/Buddhism_in_the_West_Jay_Garfield.html] - Dreyfus, G. B., <i>From Protective Deities to International Stardom: An Analysis of the Fourteenth Dalai Lama's Stance towards Modernity and Buddhism</i>, Tibetan Buddhism in the West, online [http://info-buddhism.com/Dalai_Lama_between_Modernity_and_Buddhism_by_Georges_Dreyfus.html]		

6. Challenges

Challenges facing religious thought from areas such as science, secularisation, migration and multi-cultural societies and changing gender roles

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Engaged Buddhism and Activism	- Engaged Buddhism - Buddhism and social activism	- the distinctive features of Engaged Buddhism, including: - the meaning of the term 'Engaged Buddhism', and the origins and aims of this form of practice - the significance and ideas of Thich Nhat Hanh, including the Fourteen Precepts - why a Buddhist may feel social activism is an important part of Buddhist practice - examples of Buddhist activism in the following areas: - environmental awareness and action - opposition to oppression and injustice - war and peace
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues relating to Engaged Buddhism and social activism, including: - the role and focus of Buddhists in different societies and contexts - whether or not engaged practice should be central to the Buddhist path, and how this affects the stereotypical view of Buddhism as inward-looking - whether or not a Buddhist could ever accept the need for war		
Contextual references <i>For reference, the ideas of Thich Nhat Hanh listed above can be found in:</i> - Thich Nhat Hanh (1993) <i>Interbeing: Percepts for Everyday Living</i> Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority <i>Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful</i> - Tetsuun Loy, D. Ven. Bhikkhu Bodhi and Stanley, J. <i>A Buddhist Declaration on Climate Change</i>, http://www.ecobuddhism.org/ - Plum Village, http://plumvillage.org/ - Thich Nhat Hanh (1991) <i>Peace is Every Step</i>, Rider, Part 3 - Harvey, P. (2000) <i>An Introduction to Buddhist Ethics; Foundations, Values and Issues</i>, Cambridge University Press, particularly Chapters 4 and 6		

Topic	Content	Key Knowledge
Buddhism and Gender	- Buddhist responses to the issue of gender equality, including: - female attainment of awakening - the issue of female monasticism	- whether or not this is possible, both theoretically and realistically, including: - the differing opinions of Theravada and Mahayana schools of Buddhism, with reference to The Dragon King's/Sagara's Daughter (<i>Lotus Sutra</i>, Chapter 11) - the reasons for these differing ideas, including: - their philosophical or ideological basis - the impact both of societal changes over time and the differing cultural contexts Buddhism encountered during its spread across the world - the controversy surrounding female ordination, including: - the role, origins and controversies surrounding the <i>gurudharma</i> (specific monastic rules for women) - the difficulty of ordaining women in the Theravadin tradition and the role of 'eight precept women' - Mahayana female monastic traditions and lineage - the differing status of female monastics (and 'eight precept women') in different societies, for example Thailand and Myanmar/Burma
Learners should have the opportunity to discuss issues relating to Buddhism and gender, including: - the role and aims of organisations such as the <i>Sakyadhita</i> (Daughters of the Buddha) International Association of Buddhist Women - why it is that the condition and treatment of women in Buddhism differs so widely across the world - the significance of contrasting traditional and modern views on the capacity of women to achieve enlightenment		
Suggested scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate scholarly views, academic approaches and sources of wisdom and authority, however the following examples may prove useful - Young, S. (ed) (1994) <i>An Anthology of Sacred Texts By and About Women</i>, The Crossroad Publishing Company; section on Buddhism contains texts including The Ordination of the First Nuns (taken from Culla-Vagga, X1, pp324–330) and Vimalakirti Sutra Chapter 7 (dialogue between Manjushri and Vimalakirti) - Schuster Barnes, N. (1987) <i>Buddhism</i> in Sharma, A. (ed) <i>Women in World Religions</i>, University of New York Press - Sakyadhita International Association of Buddhist Women [http://www.sakyadhita.org]		